ZHIXIN ZHOU

Psychology PhD Researcher | Child–AI Interaction · Voice AI · Mixed-Methods Research
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RESEARCH PROFILE

Psychology PhD researcher studying how children perceive, trust, and socially engage with AI, often through voice-based interactions that allow children to engage with AI conversationally. 2+ years of mixed-methods human-subjects research spanning preregistered voice-source attribution experiments, naturalistic conversations from an in-home LLM voice-chatbot deployment, and child-facing AI prototypes. Develops study protocols and qualitative coding frameworks; combines behavioral interpretation with statistical analysis in R to understand how people make sense of emerging AI.

EDUCATION

University of Louisville | Ph.D., Psychological Science — 08/2026 – 05/2031 (expected)
Advisor: Dr. Judith Danovitch

University of Pennsylvania | M.S.Ed., Interdisciplinary Studies in Human Development — 08/2024 – 05/2026
GPA 3.90/4.0 · Thesis Advisor: Dr. Michael J. Nakkula

Brandeis University | B.A., Psychology and Economics — 09/2020 – 05/2024
Minors in Education Studies, Mathematics, and Music · GPA 3.84/4.0

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Doctoral Researcher | KID Lab, University of Louisville (PI: Dr. Judith Danovitch) — 08/2026 – Present
Child-AI interaction, perceived AI authority, metacognition, and digital information seeking

- Independently designed a study of children's perceived AI authority: whether they expect AI to know moral, social-conventional, and personal rules, choose to consult it, and follow its guidance when answers conflict with rules.
- Led a study comparing web search, voice assistant, and no-search conditions to investigate children's memory, metacognition, and knowledge judgments (ages 7–12; target N=180); designed protocols and measures, created narrated AI-voice materials and a child-facing search prototype, and launched pilots.
- Co-authoring a systematic review on child development and artificial intelligence for Common Sense Media (in progress).

Graduate Researcher | Child-Centered AI Lab, Harvard Graduate School of Education (PI: Dr. Ying Xu) — 07/2025 – Present
Two projects: social cues in recorded speech and naturalistic in-home LLM voice chatbot conversations

Project 1: Social cues and AI-versus-human voice attribution

- Led study design, recruitment, and data collection for a preregistered experiment with 244 children (ages 4–11) examining how verbal social cues influence judgments of whether recorded speech comes from AI or a human.
- Cleaned and analyzed 100,000+ lines of study data in R. Initial mixed-effects analyses indicated that praise, mental-state, and emotion language reduced AI attributions, while actual source did not significantly predict judgments; co-writing the manuscript (SRCD 2027 symposium submitted).
- Created human-recorded and ElevenLabs-synthesized speech stimuli; implemented six social-cue conditions and trial-level source judgments on an online platform; refined stimuli (consistent images, child-friendly voices) following a 30-child pilot.

Project 2: Curio voice chatbot | Longitudinal, naturalistic home interactions

- Systematically coded 6,000+ child–AI dialogues from 50 children in a two-week in-home deployment of Curio, an LLM voice chatbot, to characterize spontaneous inquiries and explanations during everyday voice interactions.
- Iteratively developed and refined conversational codebooks and assessed inter-coder reliability.

Master's Thesis · Child–AI Social Engagement | University of Pennsylvania (Advisor: Dr. Michael J. Nakkula) 01/2026 – 05/2026
Independent thesis analysis of conversations from the same Curio deployment

- Developed an original three-level social-engagement coding framework and applied it to 620 personal questions in conversational chains from 52 children (ages 6–10) in the same two-week Curio home deployment.
- Distinguished child-related from agent-related questions; among 492 questions about the AI, 76% probed its identity, and 66% of those attributed an inner life (preferences, emotions, experiences, or cognition).
- Interpreted these conversational patterns as evidence of children's social sense-making about a voice agent that goes beyond information seeking; first-author SRCD 2027 poster submitted.

Graduate Researcher | RIPPLE Lab, University of Pennsylvania 01/2025 – 05/2026

- Analyzed baseline surveys from 2,476 Ghanaian adolescents and parents using reliability analysis, EFA/CFA of parenting dimensions, and latent profile analysis in R; identified four profiles and prepared a first-author manuscript (in preparation).
- Designed culturally adapted survey instruments and consent materials for IRB submission.

Graduate Researcher | Dr. Xinyin Chen's Lab, University of Pennsylvania 09/2024 – 05/2025

- Coded social-emotional behaviors across 40 free-play sessions (172 four-year-olds; 15 categories) and social-anxiety indicators in 25 sessions (100 children); refined coding protocols for reliability and longitudinal consistency.

SELECTED RESEARCH OUTPUTS

Girouard, L., **Zhou, Z.**, & Xu, Y. (submitted). Social cues shape children's judgments of AI and human informants. SRCD 2027 symposium paper; preregistered (OSF); manuscript in preparation.

Zhou, Z., Nakkula, M. J., & Xu, Y. (submitted). From tool to social partner: Children's social engagement with a voice-based AI chatbot. SRCD 2027 poster.

Zhou, Z., Huang, Y., Do, H., & Wolf, S. (in preparation). Poverty, parenting, and adolescent mental health in Ghana.

Systematic review on child development and artificial intelligence for Common Sense Media (co-author; in progress).

RESEARCH METHODS & TOOLS

Qualitative / interpretive: naturalistic conversation analysis; systematic behavioral and conversational coding; original coding frameworks and iterative codebook development; inter-coder reliability; thematic analysis.

Study design / participants: preregistered experiments (OSF); longitudinal in-home voice-chatbot research; child testing in lab, on Zoom, and online; pilot studies; recruitment; IRB protocols and CITI certification.

Audio / prototyping: human-recorded and synthetic speech stimuli (ElevenLabs); Gorilla; Qualtrics; mock search interfaces and child-facing research prototypes.

Quantitative / reporting: R (tidyverse, lme4, glmmTMB, lavaan, psych, tidyLPA, ggplot2); mixed-effects models; GLMM; factor analysis; latent profile analysis; reliability and power analysis; Mandarin Chinese (native), English (fluent).

AUDIO & MUSICAL EXPERIENCE

- Pianist for 20 years; ARSM Diploma with Distinction; chamber music, University of Pennsylvania (2024–2026). Recordings: https://zhouzhixincindy.github.io/music
- Environmental musician at Massachusetts General Hospital Cancer Center (2024): adapted piano repertoire in real time to patients' responses.